The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter

Photograph: Getty Images

In a prime-time address, **Donald Trump** said “we are on track to complete all of **America’s** military objectives shortly” in **Iran**. The president vowed to hit Iran “ extremely hard over the next two to three weeks”. He also repeated his threat to bomb the country’s energy infrastructure should its regime not agree to a deal in the coming weeks.

Mr Trump’s speech did little to soothe **oil prices** or **stockmarkets**. Brent crude, the global oil benchmark, rose while Asian indices dropped. Mr Trump blamed the “short-term” increase in petrol prices on Iran’s attacks on commercial vessels and suggested that other countries should buy oil from America, as “We have plenty.”

Meanwhile **Masoud Pezeshkian**, Iran’s president, issued an open letter to **Americans** urging them to “look beyond political rhetoric” and said relations between the two countries were undermined by “distortions and manufactured narratives”. He also signalled that Iran was open to engagement. But ultimate authority rests with the supreme leader, Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei, and it is unclear whether the letter has his backing or that of powerful military factions.

America's top Republican lawmakers announced an agreement to reopen the **Department of Homeland Security**, which has been shuttered for more than six weeks. The plan, which looks similar to one that House Republicans rejected last week, would fund the entire department, except for immigration-related agencies. Democrats are demanding restrictions on immigration enforcement. No vote is yet scheduled; Congress is in recess until mid-April.

SpaceX, Elon Musk's rocket firm, confidentially filed for an initial public offering, potentially one of the largest listings ever. Valued at more than $1trn, SpaceX is reportedly seeking to raise tens of billions of dollars. The company wants to tap public markets to fund its ambitious plans, including missions to Mars and data centres in space.

America's drug regulator approved a daily weight-loss pill from **Eli Lilly**, an American pharmaceutical giant, intensifying the firm's competition with **Novo Nordisk**, a Danish rival, in the booming market for GLP-1 treatments. Lilly's drug, called Foundayo, is less effective than injections but easier to take and cheaper. Analysts expect it to expand demand rather than replace shots.

Meg O'Neill took the helm at BP, becoming Big Oil's first female chief executive. The American, who previously led Woodside Energy, an Australian company, told BP staff she wanted to provide "clear direction" following a turbulent period. Last year the British oil major reversed a pivot into clean energy after Elliott Management, an activist hedge fund, took a stake in the firm.

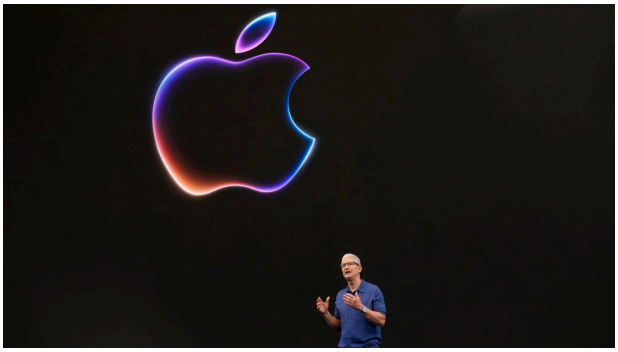
Figure of the day: 15%, the drop in the price of gold since the start of the Iran war. Is the haven asset becoming the new crypto?

Photograph: Alamy

Birthright citizenship at SCOTUS

On Wednesday Donald Trump became the first sitting president to attend an oral argument at America's Supreme Court. He listened, sometimes with eyes closed, as the justices grappled with one of his most controversial executive orders: that babies born in America to undocumented immigrants or foreign visitors should no longer be entitled to citizenship.

Trump v Barbara challenges Mr Trump's order as a violation of the 14th Amendment's guarantee of citizenship to "all persons born or naturalised in the United States, and subject to the jurisdiction thereof". Liberal and conservative justices alike were sceptical of the administration's lawyer's claim that undocumented immigrants and temporary visa-holders are not "completely subject" to federal authority because they lack a proper "domicile" in the United States. The opposing lawyer pointed to a case from 1898 involving a Chinese immigrant to argue that Mr Trump's policy departs from the constitution's long-standing historical understanding. She, too, faced tough questioning. But a majority of the justices seems inclined to preserve birthright citizenship.



Photograph: AP

Apple’s mid-life crisis

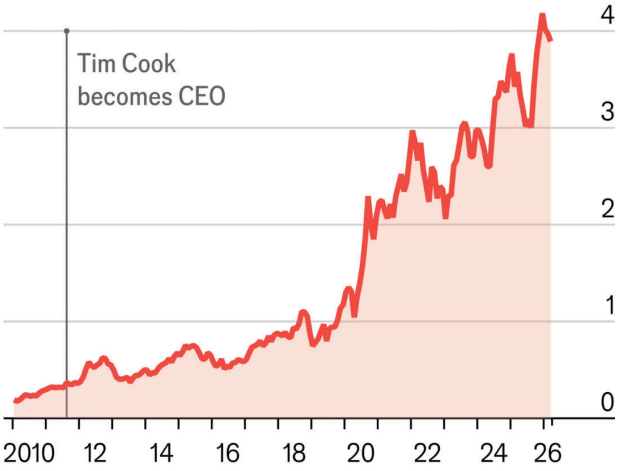
Apple celebrates its 50th birthday on Wednesday with a bash in California hosted by its boss, Tim Cook. Under his tenure, and that of his predecessor, Steve Jobs, the iPhone-maker has grown from a cultish brand into a colossus with a market value of $3.9trn.

But its fifties would be a good time for reinvention. The company wants to recapture its mojo: it is expected to introduce its first foldable phone this year and has recently released a cheap, colourful Mac laptop to widespread acclaim. New leadership could shake things up. John Ternus, head of hardware engineering, is reportedly being lined up to succeed Mr Cook.

The company is a laggard in AI: it has outsourced most of its efforts to Google’s Gemini chatbot. Siri, its voice assistant, needs to become much smarter. One day soon an AI-infused device might pose an existential threat to the iPhone. Hardware has always been Apple’s core; software remains its biggest challenge.

Juiced

Apple, market capitalisation, $trn



Source: LSEG Workspace

Photograph: Getty Images

Japan’s “singles tax” debate

On Wednesday Japan introduces its “Child and Child-Rearing Contribution” system, financed by an addition to workers’ health-insurance premiums. Whether they have children or not, every worker will pay about ¥250 ($1.60) a month to support families that do. The intention is to tackle a deepening demographic crisis. In 2024 births dropped below 700,000 for the first time, the ninth straight annual decline.

The scheme is unpopular—critics are calling it a “singles tax”. With inflation rising, the yen weak and concerns over living costs growing, many resent the idea of subsidising others’ families.

The backlash reflects a broader social shift. By 2020 single-person households accounted for nearly 40% of the Japanese total, up from about 20% in the 1980s. Over the same period, the proportion with children fell from roughly 42% to 25%. A policy meant to coax singles into forming families has instead provoked their fury.

Illustration: Sandra Navarro

Daily quiz

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 GMT on Friday to . We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: Who was the only American president to be born in Missouri?

Tuesday: Who served as both American ambassador to the United Nations and director of the CIA in the 1970s?

When you want to fool the world, tell the truth.

Otto von Bismarck